

THE VEILWRACK: THE STILLING

Fourth Wall Gaming

CHAPTER 1 — THE COMMANDER’S TERMS



He came to Lanternfall Spire in the season of the High Gales, in the thousand-and-first year of a Record he no longer entirely believed, with breath-bottles, cold-wax, a name the Deepway would not say aloud, and a debt that belonged to a dead man.

The spire rose out of the brass haze like the rib of something that had once been too large for the sky to refuse — which was, of course, exactly what it was. Three thousand souls roosted on the bones of the dead leviathan, most of them Roak lamp-crafters, and their lamps climbed its western face in great descending rings, orange above, deepening toward gold below, down and down toward the Undermist, so that in the last light the spire seemed a thing already half-swallowed, wearing its own drowning as jewelry. Its windlane had begun to die that season. Vorrh had heard it said in three ports before he came. Nobody flies *toward* a Stilling.

He did. He had his reasons, and he told them to no one, and the first person on Lanternfall to get any of them out of him was the commander of the Warden draft, because she asked.

Esk Veil-Torn received him in the old beacon-keeper’s gallery, standing, with a decade of dead windlanes charted on the walls behind her in flat red tide-marks. She was Vael, scarred along the jaw and the left wing-root, and she read his papers — diver’s certification from Carrowspar, the only legal Undermist training in the sky; no current

Deepway standing; the gap in the record where his standing used to be — the way she presumably read everything, once, completely, without comment.

“An Ossuin death-diver with no order,” she said. “Cast out for what?”

“Asking a question twice.”

“What question?”

“How a funeral record could be complete when I was there and it wasn’t.”

Esk looked at him for a moment over the top of the papers. Whatever the look cost her, she paid it without expression. “I command survey on a dying lane, diver. I lose tools, I lose charts, and some seasons I lose fliers, and I have read every record the Wardens hold on every one of them, and I will tell you what I have learned about complete records.” She set the papers down. “There is no such thing. There is only what came back up the tether. You’ll do.”

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The terms took less time than the papers had.

“One condition, and it is not negotiable, and it is the same one I give everyone.” She came around the chart-table and stood in the late brass light from the horn panes, arms folded. “I am told first. About everything. Before your conscience, before your gods, before whatever order threw you out and whatever you still owe it. Whatever you find down there — whatever you see, whatever you break, whatever you bring up that you wish you hadn’t — I hear it first, and I hear all of it. I don’t pay for heroics and I don’t forgive surprises. The Stilling gives me enough of those.”

“And in exchange?”

“In exchange I tell you the truth back, which you will discover is not a common arrangement on this spire, or any other.” She said it without bitterness, as a measurement. “Honest accounting, both directions. That’s the whole contract. Everything else is rates.”

Vorrr had stood in the Synod’s halls and been ordered to unhear a singing. He had carried a question through two askings and an exile because no one in the Deepway would deal with him plainly. He looked at this torn, economical woman with her wall of dead lanes, offering him truth-for-truth as if it were a standard clause, and he thought: *I have flown a long way to find the thing I was thrown out for asking, and it is a hiring term in a doomed survey draft.*

“Agreed,” he said. “First, and all of it.”

“Then you’re mine. Welcome to the dying lane.” She turned back to the table, and he thought the audience was over, and he was wrong. Her voice changed — not softened; *narrowed*, the way a lamp narrows to a beam. “There’s one more thing you’ll want before you go below. Not an order. A briefing. You’re Ossuin; your people keep the descents and the dead. So you should know what this spire has already lost down there, because you’ll be working over the top of it.”

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“Tilve Wickmend,” Esk said. “Lamp-tender, western face — the rings you’ll dive past every morning of your contract. Nine years on the lamps. Two years ago she went below the skim on a tether, past the root-line, and came up alive.” A beat. “She hasn’t spoken since. Not a word, not a written one. The crews call her the hushed lampwright, mostly when they think she can’t hear them, which is always. Which is the problem.”

The brass light moved on the dying charts.

“She still lights every lamp,” Esk said. “Every ring, every night, to the minute, nine years of schedule and the silence hasn’t taken one wick from her. And every night, when the lowest ring is lit, she stands at the western root-line and counts. The diver’s count — you’d know it better than I would. Eighty-one beats.” Esk’s arms stayed folded. “And stops. Eighty-one, and stops. Every night, two years, never one beat more, and the watch-wardens will swear it has never varied. Whatever she went down to find, diver, she is still counting toward it, and the count does not finish.”

“What was she diving for?” Vorrh asked. His voice came out level, which was a craftsman’s piece of work, because the floor of him had gone out somewhere around *the western root-line*. A lamp-tender of Lanternfall. On a tether, past the root-line, two years ago. He carried, wrapped in cold-wax against his breastbone, a ring spliced of sinew, broken once, mended toward a lamp-tender of Lanternfall — and he had crossed the sky to find her, and had not yet so much as asked her name in the roost-halls, and now it was given to him unasked, by a commander honoring a contract one minute old. *Told first. Both directions.*

“For a body,” Esk said. “Her betrothed went under at the skim on a Deepway dive two years back. The Synod’s record says he was carried down — complete, sealed, all the right words. She went down anyway. Make of that what you like.” She looked at him, and there was nothing in her face but the measurement, and the measurement was thorough. “You asked your order how a record could be complete when you were there and it wasn’t. So I’ll tell you what the western face thinks of complete records, diver: there’s a woman down on the lowest ring who has been silent for two years, counting to eighty-one, and the record says she has nothing left to wait for.”

Vorrh said nothing. The ring lay against his breastbone like a coal.

“Survey brief is at the stage at dawn,” Esk said, returning to her charts. “Go settle in. And Vorrh —” she did not look up — “whatever it is you flew here carrying: first, and all of it. That clause has no exceptions, and you have until dawn.”

CHAPTER 2 — THE RING



He found her on the lowest ring before the dawn brief, in the hour when the lamps come down — when a tender walks the western face snuffing the night's wicks in order, highest to lowest, so that the light withdraws down the spire ahead of the day like a tide going home to the gold.

Tilve Wickmend worked without hurry and without waste, a small Roak woman with wax-scarred hands, and Vorrh stood at the rail of the ring-walk and watched her tend three lamps before he could make himself approach, because the Deepway trains its divers for every silence in the world except this one. At the lowest ring the lamps burned strangely — faintly blue at the wick-heart, a colour he had no entry for in any table he'd been taught — and she mended as she went, he saw: wicks another tender would have stripped and discarded, she trimmed, and coaxed, and kept.

She knew he was there. She did not turn. He understood, watching the line of her back, that people had been *at* her for two years — the concerned, the curious, the cruel — and that her stillness was a wall built one visitor at a time.

So he did not say any of the things the visitors would have said. He stood at the working distance a lamp-tender's courtesy allows, and said, in the descent-cadence, the speech-rhythm of Carrowspar that every Deepway household in the sky would know from its funerals:

“My name is Vorrh. I was stair-cohort to Hollm, named the held breath at the same first descent. I was on the tether the day he went below the skim, and the record they sealed of that day is false, and I have always known it was false, and I have come a long way to say so to the one person it was sealed against.”

The wick-knife stopped.

She did not turn for a long moment, and when she did her face was not what he had braced for. Not grief, not the wild thing the roost-hall whispers implied. Attention. Total, fathomless attention, like the flat light off a still pocket, like the held gap in a chant — a listening so complete it had stopped leaving room for anything to be said back.

He took the bundle from against his breastbone and unwound the cold-wax in front of her, kneeling at the ring-walk rail, the way offerings are unwrapped at Carrowspar: deliberately, both hands shown. Inside lay the small waxed bone with its two written words. And riding the bone, where it had ridden two years through every port and every silence he had carried it: the ring. Spliced sinew, diver-made — Hollm’s own splice, Vorrh knew the lay of his brother’s cordwork the way one knows a voice — broken once, and mended, the mend turned inward, *toward her*, the way a maker mends a thing whose breaking he cannot forgive himself.

“He was coming back to you,” Vorrh said. “Whatever called him below the skim, he went under wearing this with the mend turned toward Lanternfall. I found him at the reef-bone months after, one arm raised toward the surface. No one carried him down. No one witnessed but me, after. The Synod wrote *complete and sealed* over an empty rite, and they handed you the seal and called it a husband.” His voice held the cadence; the cadence was the only thing holding it. “The bone is witnessed, and the carrying-down is mine to finish — that debt is the Deepway’s and I am keeping it whether the Deepway will say my name or not. But the ring was never the dark’s. It was mended toward you. I have carried it wrong for two years.”

He held it out: the ring alone, freed of the wax.

Tilve Wickmend looked at the ring, and at him, and at the ring. Below them the skim turned over, gold on slow gold, with the patience of a thing that is owed everything and can wait. Her scarred hand came out and closed around the splice — not snatching, not trembling; *receiving*, with the exact economy of a tender taking a lamp into keeping — and she pressed her closed fist once against her sternum, where a word would have lived if she had any left.

Then she turned and went back to her wicks.

That was all. It was not nothing. He had been raised on liturgies and had just watched one, complete in every part, performed in one gesture by a silent woman with wax-scarred hands; and as he wound the cold-wax back around the bone alone, it occurred to Vorrh that of the two of them, she had just spoken and he had just listened, and the Synod could have learned something from either half of it.

Behind him as he climbed for the dawn brief, eighty-one lamps burned down the western face, and one tender moved among them, and the lowest wicks burned blue.

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Esk was at her charts when he came back up, as if she had not moved in the night, and he kept the contract one minute ahead of his courage:

“First, and all of it,” Vorrh said. “I came to Lanternfall for your lampwright. My stair-cohort brother was her betrothed. This morning I gave her his ring, and she kept it. And there is a thing I have to do at the skim, and I am asking your leave to do it.”

He told her all of it — the false record, the bone, the carrying-down owed; that the survey contract would take him to the skim above the very root-line where Hollm went under; that an Ossuin debt that old does not wait for a convenient season. He asked for the rite.

Esk heard him out, arms folded, with the dead lanes at her back, and when he finished she was quiet for the space of three lamp-calls from below.

“Conditions,” she said. “Three. The survey comes first — every measurement on the contract, complete, before you spend one breath on the dead; I am not sending a grieving man down a dying lane, I am sending a surveyor down with grief in his kit, and you will keep them in that order. Second: my clause, no exceptions, *especially* below — everything that happens at that skim comes back up to me, first and whole, whatever it is, however it sounds. Third: you dive on Warden tether discipline, full crew, drum and count, none of your order’s lonescent doctrine. If the dead are owed a rite, the living are owed a line.”

“Agreed,” Vorrh said. “All three.”

“Then you have my leave.” She turned to the gallery door and raised her voice exactly as much as it needed. “Kithrel.”

The flier came in from the landing-walk with the dawn behind her — Vael, quick-eyed, lane-tokens braided into her primaries, where they clicked very faintly when she moved, like small bones agreeing with each other.

“Kithrel of the Moul. Best survey-flier in the draft; she’s flown every Stilling edge since Greywake closer than regulations allow, and she keeps a count the way the Quillate keeps a ledger.” Esk’s eyes came back to Vorrh, and there was, for the first time, something underneath the measurement — not warmth; *placement*, a commander setting two pieces where they belonged on a board only she could see whole. “She holds your line and your count today. Brief her on all of it — the contract, the survey, and the rite. She holds the count for *everything* you do down there, diver. That’s the condition under the conditions.”

Kithrel looked him over once, survey-fashion, missing nothing — the bottles, the wax, the new grief worn old.

“Contract’s the edge,” she said. “Chart the pocket, sound the margins, come back. I’ll learn the rest on the stage.” And then, with the first and only softness anyone had spent on him since he made landfall: “I keep good count, Deepway. Nobody goes off my line.”

The sun cleared the haze to the east, and the last of Tilve's lamps went out below them, right on schedule, and the three of them went down to the diving stage together.

CHAPTER 3 — THE GOLD BELOW



Dawn came up the western face of Lanternfall Spire the colour of old brass, and Vorrh stood on the diving stage with the wind worrying the wax seals of his breath-bottles and thought, as he always thought before a descent: *the dead go down, all of them, even mine.*

Below him the Undermist lay like a sea of molten gold, lambent, depthless, beautiful in the way that drowned things are beautiful. The Alar called its surface the skim, and they had charted it for a thousand years, and this morning it was two hundred meters higher than any chart said it should be. Nobody on the stage had remarked on that yet. Vorrh had learned, in his exile, that there were two kinds of silence: the kind people kept, and the kind that kept people. He was no longer always sure which one he was standing in.

The drum-master checked his tether — spliced sinew, cold-waxed, rated for a body and a half, which was the Deepway's old joke and not a joke at all. Above, on the survey perch, Kithrel of the Moults settled into the count-keeper's cradle with her dead flight's lane-tokens braided into her primaries, clicking faintly, a sound like small bones agreeing with each other.

"Survey first," she called down — Esk's first condition, worn smooth already by one morning's handling. "Every measurement on the contract before you spend a breath on the dead. You keep them in that order and I keep the count."

“I remember the order.”

“Remember the other thing.” *Nobody goes off my line.* She did not say it again; she let the morning say it for her, and began the count, slow and metronomic, the diver-tender’s pulse that would follow him down the tether like a second heartbeat: *one, and one, and one.*

He stepped off the stage and let the world take him.

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The descent was clean. That was the first wrongness, though he did not name it so until later: two hundred and eighty meters of falling dawn, the spire-root sliding past him scabbed with reef-bone and abandoned lamp-rings, and not one gust crossed him, not one shear, nothing. The air parted for him as courteously as a Crown agent’s smile. A diver of the Deepway is taught to mistrust an easy stair. Vorrh had been cast out of the Deepway for asking questions, but they had never managed to take the teaching back.

At depth he hung in his harness in the gold light coming up off the skim, and the still pocket stood off to the west of him like a guest who has arrived early to a funeral.

You could not see it, exactly. That was the obscenity of it. The Stilling had no edge the eye could fix — only a region where the brass light went somehow flat, where the air gave up the small ceaseless conversation that living air conducts with itself, and the world looked like a painting of the world. Beneath his dread, and he was honest enough to admit the dread, ran a thinner, worse thread, a yearning with a number on it in some Warden ledger somewhere: *I have heard you before, and I have wanted to hear you again every day since.*

He unstoppered the first sounding-rite instead.

The Mist-Rites of Carrowspar are humble sorcery, folk-craft, a few breath-borne syllables that go out into the murk and come back changed, and from the changing a trained ear reads distance, density, the architecture of vapour. Vorrh cast the first rite toward the pocket’s margin and the syllables went out true — and smeared. They came

back to him like drowned men, their consonants eaten, their distances slurred into one another, useless. He hung in his harness and listened to his own craft fail and felt the fine hairs of his nape rise.

He cast again, and this time spent against the failure the last of what a diver hoards — the gambler's grace, the held favour, the luck a man burns when skill is not enough. It bought him nothing. The second casting died worse than the first.

But dying, it told him something. The early-failing syllables — the ones that should have scattered at random, eaten by random vapour — had all died *in the same direction*. Westward. Toward the pocket. As if something in the silence had reached out along each thread of sound and pinched it, one by one, with the unhurried thoroughness of a lamp-tender going down a ring of wicks.

"You are not weather," Vorrh said to the west, very quietly, in the tone the catechism reserves for things that might be listening. "Weather does not choose."

The silence did not answer. That, too, he would remember later, and understand differently.

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What he could measure, he measured, because Esk Veil-Torn paid for measurements and because numbers were the only prayer he had left. The pocket's upper margin rode at two hundred and eighty meters below the stage — twenty meters shallower than the commander's newest chart, a chart inked less than a season ago. He ran the figures twice. The chart was not wrong. The chart had been right, and then the world had moved.

And the margin itself would not hold still for him. Each time he fixed its edge against a lamp-ring or a knuckle of reef-bone, the flatness had crept, or withdrawn, or breathed — a tide-line, he thought, with a lurch of recognition, for he had spent his whole life beside the one tide the Alar know, the slow gold swell of the Undermist itself. The Stilling's edge was not a border. It was a shore. And shores belong

to seas, and seas have movements of their own, and things that move in them.

Far above, threadbare with distance, Kithrel's count came down the tether: *and one, and one, and one*. The most ordinary sound in the sky. He had never in his life been so glad of anything so small.

Vorrh hung between the risen gold and the creeping silence, took out his survey slate, and wrote what no chart in the Veilwrack yet said: *Pocket top 280. Edge tidal — unfixed. Soundings die westward, all of them, together.*

Then, because he was Ossuin, and because the skim below him had risen two hundred meters like a thing swelling toward a surface, he wrote one line more, in the small precise hand the Deepway had taught him for the recording of deaths:

Something down here is closer than it was.

CHAPTER 4 — THE FUNERAL OF HOLLM



The skim had risen to four hundred meters, and Vorrh went down to meet it, and this part of the dive was on no contract and in no ledger, and he had known since before dawn that he was going to do it anyway.

The surface of the Undermist up close is not like gold at all. Gold is honest metal; it lies still. The skim moved — a slow iridescent crawl, currents of brass and chalcedony and a colour like lamplight through wax that has no name in any of the three kindreds' tongues, all of it turning over with the patience of something that has been digesting a world for longer than the Record runs. Carrowspar's catechism says the dead go down through it to the Worldlung's keeping. Vorrh had believed that once, entirely, the way a child believes in the floor.

He found the place by memory. Reef-bone to the north, the drowned lamp-ring westward, and below — months below, and one unsanctioned dive, and one snagged arm raised toward a surface it never reached — the place where he had found his brother.

Hollm. Named at their shared first descent: *the held breath*. Stair-cohort, wing-brother, betrothed of a lamp-tender of Lanternfall whose wedding had been set for the Wet. The Synod's record of his death read *Carried down, complete, sealed* — a proper funeral for a death no one had witnessed, of a body no one had carried. Vorrh had asked how

a record could be complete when he had been there and it wasn't. He had asked twice. The asking was his whole exile.

From the cold-wax wrapping at his breast he took the small waxed bone — lighter now, since dawn, by the weight of a ring; the splice rode the lowest ring of Lanternfall in a lamp-tender's keeping, where it had always belonged — on which he had written, in the recording hand, two words: *witnessed: Vorrh*.

"By the Stair and the wax and the long way down," he said, "I will do this by the book they cast me out of. Let them say the form was wrong. Let them say the diver was wrong. They will not say it was not done."

He began the cohort descent-rite alone, and that was his first mistake, and he made it on purpose.

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The rite is built for many voices. He had always known this the way one knows a doctrine; he learned it now the way one learns a wound. The descent-chant walks in three parts — the calling voice, the answering voice, and the cohort-silence between them, the held gap into which the answer must fall on the rest-length, exact, or the form is broken. One mouth cannot call and answer both. He tried. The first passage collapsed on the turn, his answering line arriving into a silence still warm from his own calling, graceless, late, *wrong*, and the gold turned over below him with sublime indifference.

He tried again, by the book, every syllable weighed, and broke it worse.

And hanging there with the ruin of the form in his mouth, Vorrh understood — with the cold, vertiginous clarity that comes to a man precisely when he can least afford it — what the failure *was*. The cohort-rite cannot be performed by one voice. Not poorly. Not at all. Structurally, doctrinally, in its very bones, it cannot. Which meant the Synod's record — *carried down, complete, sealed*, the rite performed entire for a body never found, by witnesses never named — described a thing that could not happen. The record was not mistaken. The record

was an impossibility, written down and sealed by men who knew the form better than anyone alive.

They had not papered over a death. They had papered over the *rite itself*.

“What did you hear that day,” he whispered to the gold, “that was worth all of this quiet?”

He set himself, a third time, into the calling passage. The chant went out over the skim. He reached the turn, and held the cohort-silence open — the gap where the answering voice belongs, the rest he could not fill —

— and the silence to the west *leaned in*.

There is no other rendering of it. The still pocket, the dead air, the flat region where his soundings had gone to die — it came up against the open gap of the rite and *held it*. Held the rest. Perfectly. Not a sound; the precise, fluent, deliberate *shape* of where a sound would be, sustained for the exact rest-length the form demands, the way a cantor who has sung a liturgy ten thousand times holds a caesura. The most beautiful answering-silence Vorrh had ever been given in his life, and it came from the thing that was eating the sky.

His chant broke. Not the form this time — the man. His voice cracked off the rest-length and scattered, and he grabbed for the tether like a fledgling, and somewhere in that long falling moment he reached for the one ordinary thing the world had left him, Kithrel’s count coming down the line, *and one, and one* —

The count was gone.

No tether-pulse. No metronome. Nothing above him and nothing below him and the great fluent attentive silence to the west, waiting, with perfect courtesy, for his next line.

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He did not give it the form. Some stubborn marrow-deep thing — the same thing that had asked the Synod its question twice — refused to

feed one more syllable of the Deepway's liturgy into whatever was down here practising it.

He finished the funeral in his own words. They were not good words. He said that Hollm had been the better diver and the worse cardplayer; that he had folded his wings toward a singing no one else had been permitted to hear, and that whatever had called him was a thief, whatever it was, however beautiful; that a lamp-tender on Lanternfall had been handed a sealed lie instead of a husband, and that this morning she had taken back the one true thing he'd had to give her, and that the lie, of everything, remained unforgiven. He said the dead go down, all of them, even his. He unwound the cold-wax for the last time.

The bone he gave to the gold.

It went under without a ripple, the way everything goes under, the way nine thousand went at Greywake — received, absorbed, kept. *Witnessed: Vorrh.* The only true line in the whole of the Synod's record, and he had had to write it himself.

"The count is broken," he said to the skim, to the west, to whatever held caesuras in the deep. "His count stopped at the wrong number and no one finished it. I will finish it. By the Stair and the wax — that one is mine."

His luck was spent to the last grace. His voice was gone to a rasp. Four hundred meters of unknown air stood between him and the stage, and his soundings were dead, and the silence had stopped leaning in — which ought to have been a comfort.

It was not a comfort. A thing that leans in can lean *after*. He took hold of the tether and began to climb.

CHAPTER 5 — THE FINGER OF SILENCE



The climb began badly and then taught him what badly meant.

Vorrh was wrung out — voice gone, grace gone, arms full of the particular lead that follows grief performed under load — and he climbed the way tired divers climb, by rote, wings half-set to the updraught, trusting the tether-line the way one trusts a stair one has used all one's life. At two hundred and ninety meters the stair betrayed him.

He flew into dead air.

There was no warning, because warning is a property of living air — pressure, sound, the murmur of the world — and all of it stopped at once, as if he had climbed through a pane of glass into a painting. His wings bit nothing they understood. The tether-pulse vanished under his hand. The lamplight from the rings above came through flat and wrong, light with the life skinned off it, and the silence took him in the chest the way deep cold takes a man: not as absence but as *pressure*, immediate, total, interested.

The dead band lay straight across his tether-line. It had not been there at his descent. The pocket had moved — no. He understood even as he dropped, wings folding, letting his own weight pull him back down out of the flat horror into air that breathed: the pocket had not moved.

The pocket had *reached*.

He hung below the band gasping in the living air, and the catechism rose in him unbidden — *that the dark is answering back* — and he put it down, and did what Wardens pay for and the Deepway trains for. He traversed east, well clear, and looked at the thing properly, and the looking was the finest piece of survey work he would ever do, and he would have given anything not to be its only witness.

It was a finger.

Eight meters thick, perhaps, smooth-flanked as a windworked column, a bar of perfected stillness extruded from the western pocket's mass across two hundred meters of open sky. Not a front, not a tide-line, not weather. A *limb*. And its axis — he ran the line twice, three times, against the lamp-rings and the spire-root and the drowned geometry he had fixed all morning — its axis pointed, exactly, with a draughtsman's contempt for coincidence, at the patch of skim where he had performed his brother's funeral.

It had not drifted across his tether. It had reached out along the line of his rite — toward the place where a single voice had held the cohort-gap open, toward the spot where a waxed bone had gone into the gold — reached *for* it, along a bearing, to a destination. While he had hung at the skim giving the dark his own words, this had been above him the whole time, extended over his head like a listener's arm along the back of a pew.

And now, with the rite ended and the bone given, it was going home. He fixed its tip against a lamp-ring and watched. Half a meter to the minute, smooth, unhurried, the silence drawing back into the silence — a thing retiring, replete. *Done listening*.

The survey-slate was in his hand without his deciding it. The recording hand wrote: *Band is extrusion from W pocket. Axis bears on rite-site. Withdrawal ~0.5 m/min, begun after rite's end*. The letters were steady. He was not.

"You heard the whole thing," he said. His ruined voice made it a whisper, which felt, in the flat light off the finger's flank, hideously appropriate. "You held the rest-length. You *waited for the end*."

The finger withdrew, half a meter to the minute, and declined to be questioned, and that was the answer.

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The count did not come back.

That was the arithmetic of his situation, and he did the sum hanging east of the withdrawing finger with his voice gone and his luck spent and four hundred meters of sky between himself and the stage. The band had lain across his tether-line, and whatever it had eaten of Kithrel's count it had not given back: the line under his hand stayed mute, no pulse, no metronome, no *and one, and one*. He was a Deepway diver, and a Deepway diver without a count is a man told, in the politest possible terms, that he is alone.

The doctrine for a dead line is the doctrine he had been raised on: hold position, conserve, trust the crew to read the silence and haul. But the haul would come up through the band — through the finger, through the working silence — and every instinct in him, catechism and survey-craft agreeing for once like estranged brothers, said *do not be on that line when it crosses*. So he did the thing his order calls apostasy and the Wardens call Tuesday.

He cast off the tether-pulse, set his wings, and flew.

It nearly killed him. He would write it smaller than that for the report, and the report would still be the most alarming document Esk Veil-Torn read that season, but the truth was the truth: he was wrung dry, grief-heavy, climbing dawn-shear with no count to pace him and no luck left to spend, and twice the updraught dropped him and he fell shrieking distance before his wings found purchase in air that consented to be flown. The Undermist turned over below him, gold, patient, risen, and he climbed away from it one ragged wingbeat at a time with his brother's funeral still in his throat, and there was no rhythm to hold to except the one he made himself — and what he made, without deciding to, was the diver's count. *One, and one, and one*. Counting himself up the sky like a man going down it.

He passed the height where the band had been and the world came back on like a lamp — sound and shear and the blessed petty commerce of moving air — and somewhere far above he caught it at last, threadbare with distance: *and one, and one*, faint, furious, unbroken. She had never stopped. All that time he had been deaf in the gold, Kithrel had been counting into the thing that ate it, and something in his chest went loose at the ordinariness of the sound, which he was wise enough to recognize as the closest thing to rescue that morning was going to offer him.

He hooked an arm at last through the corroded mounting of the lowest ring's last orange lamp and hung, breathing, alive, solvent in nothing but information. Kithrel stooped down to him there, having left the stage the moment he cleared the haze, and looked him over the way she had looked him over at dawn, survey-fashion, missing nothing.

"Drum-master wanted to haul you up through it," she said. "Dead line means dead diver, he says. I told him dead air that moves is doing something, and you don't crank a tether through a thing that's working." A click of lane-tokens. "You were off my line, Deepway. Don't make a habit of it."

"The line was off me," Vorrh rasped. "I'll say so in the report."

"You'll say everything in the report. She'll see to that." And Kithrel flew up ahead of him to call the stage off its alarm, and left him hanging on the lamp his brother's betrothed would light that evening, on schedule, to the minute.

And what information. He assembled it on the slate while his arms shook, in the recording hand, for Esk, who paid for measurements: *Pocket top 280, not 300. Skim risen to 400, not 600. The edge is a tide and will not chart. And the silence reaches toward sustained sound — deliberately, along a bearing, to a place — and withdraws when the sound is done.*

Four findings. Three of them made every chart in the Warden draft obsolete.

The fourth made obsolete something he did not yet have a word for, and the lack of the word followed him all the way up the last hundred meters like a finger laid along his spine.

CHAPTER 6 — WHAT THE DIVER SAID



Commander Esk Veil-Torn kept her chart-room in the old beacon-keeper's gallery on Lanternfall's western face, where the light came in late and brass-coloured through panes of scraped horn, and the walls were charts, and the charts were dying.

That was how Vorrh had thought of it since his first hour in the draft. Other commanders hung trophies. Esk hung the Greywake windlane, inked by some Moult chart-singer a decade gone, with its lane-shrines and its tally-knots and its margins annotated in three hands — and across it, in the Warden draft's flat red, the creeping season-lines of the Stilling that had swallowed it. Lane after lane along the gallery wall, each with its red tide-marks. A library of obituaries. She worked with her back to none of them. She had earned her deed-name going into the Greywake silence after her wing-sister, and had come out alone, torn, carrying the body anyway, and it was said in the draft that she had hung that chart where visitors would have to look at it so that she would never have to explain herself twice.

She heard his report standing, arms folded, and did not interrupt once. That was her way; she was economical, scrupulously fair, allergic to speeches, and she paid for measurements.

He gave her measurements.

"Your charts put the pocket's top at three hundred meters. It rides at two hundred and eighty. The chart isn't in error — the chart was

right when it was inked, this season. The pocket has come up twenty meters since.” He laid the survey slate on her table, turned for her reading. “Your charts put the skim at six hundred. It stands at four hundred. And the pocket’s edge cannot be charted at all, by me or anyone, because it is not a border. It moves between fixes. It’s a tide-line, Commander. We have all been drawing shores on maps and calling them walls.”

Esk’s eyes went along the slate line by line. “And the soundings?”

“Dead. All of them. The rites smear and fail — and they fail westward, every casting, together, toward the pocket.” He paused, and then gave her the rest, because he had decided on the climb that she would have all of it. “It reaches, Commander. While I was at the skim it extruded a limb of dead air eight meters thick across two hundred meters of open sky. I flew into it on the ascent. When I cleared it and fixed its line, its axis bore exactly on the patch of skim where I was working. It reached toward a sustained sound, along a bearing, to a place. And when the sound ended, it withdrew — half a meter to the minute, smooth, like a man drawing back his hand from a table.”

The chart-room was quiet. Below the horn panes, faint and ceaseless, the evening commerce of the spire went on: wings, pulley-squeal, a lamp-crew calling its ring-count down the western face.

“Toward a sustained sound,” Esk said. “What sound?”

He could have said *survey casting*. The slate would have borne him out. But she had given him leave for the rite under three conditions and the second had no exceptions, *especially below*, and he had agreed with the dawn not an hour old; and besides, he found he did not want the door the lie held open. He had crossed a sky to get away from sealed records.

“The funeral,” Vorrh said. “The rite you gave me leave for. I tried the descent-chant alone, by the book, twice, and the form broke both times, and I learned why: the cohort-rite cannot be performed by one voice — not poorly; not at all. Which is the last thing I will ever need to know about the Synod’s record, because the record swears that rite was performed entire, by witnesses never named, for a body never

found. Then I tried a third time, and when I held the cohort-gap open — the answering-rest, the gap a second voice fills — the silence held it with me. On the rest-length. Fluently. Like a voice that knew the liturgy. After that I gave the dark my own words, and the bone with them, and the limb withdrew, and your flier's count was waiting for me above the band, and that is the whole of it, in order, as agreed." His voice was still a rasp; it made the words sound older than they were. "First, and all of it."

Esk looked at him for a long moment, with the dying lanes of a decade hung at her back.

"That's why you fly for *me*," she said, which from Esk Veil-Torn was a commendation with full honours. She turned the slate face-down, deliberately, the gesture of a woman closing one ledger and opening a worse one. Then she went back along his report the way she went along a chart, fix by fix, and he watched her arrive where he had been trying not to stand since the climb.

"Walk it again," she said. "The limb crossed your tether-line on the ascent — a line that wasn't there at your descent. Its axis bore on your rite-site. Your soundings died westward, *all of them, together*, from your first casting of the morning — before the rite, before the funeral, before you gave it one syllable of liturgy." Her arms came unfolded; she set both hands flat on the chart-table, and for the first time since he had known her the economy in her face looked like what it had always been, which was armour. "Diver, I have been charting the Stilling as weather for ten years. Weather doesn't take a bearing. That thing wasn't drifting across your morning. It was *following* it. It found your sound, and it tracked the sound to you, and when you stopped making it, it withdrew and went home — and it knows, now, where the sounds of this spire come up from. We didn't survey the dead air today." The brass light moved on the dead lanes behind her. "It surveyed *us*."

The lamp was the loudest thing in the room for a while.

“And it will have heard more than my rite,” Vorrh said. “The lamp-calls. The drum. The whole western face, every dawn and dusk, on schedule, to the minute.”

“To the minute,” Esk agreed, flat as the flat light he had hung in, and let the arithmetic of that sit between them. Then: “There’s one more fix, and you’ve earned the bad half of this too. Tilve Wickmend stood her count last night, at the western root-line, on the watch’s record like every night for two years. Eighty-one beats, the wardens will swear, never one more.” A beat, measured, like a count of her own. “Last night it went to eighty-two.”

“Last night,” Vorrh said. *While I was below.* The floor of him had not come back since dawn; it went further away now. His brother’s count had stopped at the wrong number and no one had finished it; he had sworn at the skim, to the gold, to whatever held caesuras in the deep, *I will finish it* — and the same night, on the face above his rite, a count two years frozen had moved one beat. The sky had its own broken counts, and they were moving, and they were moving *together*.

“First change in two years, the same night an Ossuin diver holds a funeral at the skim and the silence answers it back,” Esk said. “I command a survey draft, Vorrh. I am paid to mistrust coincidence, and I find I cannot afford this one.”

She did not say: *and this morning you put a ring in that woman’s hand.* She did not have to. It was in the room with them, in her clause and his agreement, first and all of it, both directions.

“Kithrel talked my drum-master out of hauling you up through the middle of that limb — on her own authority, which she did not have, and which I have just given her retroactively because she was right. She’s offered to stand the night watches on the western face. Unpaid.” A dry flicker. “The Moults do not offer unpaid anything, so you might consider what she thinks she’s watching over.”

“Commander,” Vorrh said, “what is your question?”

Because there was one. He had learned her that well at least: Esk Veil-Torn did not deal in revelations, she dealt in decisions, and she had not turned that slate face-down to share his awe.

She straightened from the chart-table. Behind her the dead lanes hung in their red tide-marks, and below the horn panes the lamp-crews called their counts, and somewhere down the western face a silent woman was lighting the evening rings on schedule, eighty-two beats into a count whose ending no one living knew.

“The count moved when you gave the silence what it wanted,” Esk said. “So you tell me, diver — you that it answered. The lamp-crews say the full diver’s count runs to one hundred and eight. What happens when she gets there?” The brass light through the horn was going out of the room by degrees, the way it went out of everything. “And do I hope for it — or do I post wardens to stop it?”

The lamps came on, ring below ring below ring, down into the dark.